

India UNPREPARED

Despite imminent threats, the anti-terror response is stymied by red tapism and the states' inertia

| By Sandeep Unnithan |

The warning is direct and disturbing. The Lashkar-e-Toiba (LeT) is making concerted efforts to organise terrorist attacks on the western coastal areas, particularly in Gujarat, Maharashtra and Goa. "The LeT is likely to target iconic institutions, prominent industrial installations and tourist locations along the coast with a view to create panic and project India as unsafe for tourists and foreign investors." (For full text of the letter log in to www.indiatoday.in)

This June 26 alert from the Intelligence Bureau (IB) was not specific, yet prompted a massive alert along the west coast. The alert, a copy of which is with INDIA TODAY, mentions "Pakistan-based LeT commanders as having directed their Indian associates to identify locations along the coastal areas particularly Mandvi and north of Koteswar port in Kutch, Gujarat, to establish hideouts. Indian associates have also been directed to procure mechanised boats to be used for transportation of weapons."

The LeT leadership, including Hafiz Saeed and Zakiur Rehman, are free to plan more attacks as the recent arrest of its operative Mohammed Omar Madni from Delhi proves. Senior US officials warn of there being a "more than 90 per cent chance" of a fresh attack on India to distract from Pakistan's war in the east. Indian military planners warn that another attack will bring the two countries into yet another devastating war.

The stakes for preventing another terror strike have never been higher.



Yet, the UPA-II's 100-day mandate promises action on every front but is silent on the security threats. Home Minister P. Chidambaram has promised action and has delivered on certain fronts but the system seems very slow and incapable of moving. "There has been a tremendous augmentation of force at the Centre but a negligible force increase at the state level," says Ajai Sahni, executive director of Delhi-based Institute of Conflict Management. This imbalance between the Centre and states which are the first responders to any terror attack, is what will make the crucial difference when the next attack comes.

NO EQUIPMENT FOR NSG

FLAW NSG has insufficient state-of-the-art equipment to tackle terrorists

SOLUTION Fast-track procurement of special equipment

STORY SO FAR Equipment will take months to arrive

2/10

Seven months ago, the Black Cats sbattled the odds—and a critical shortage of specialised equipment—to overwhelm the eight terrorists in Mumbai. A National Security Guard (NSG) officer lost an eye because he did